

Two Women

1869

A POEM

BY
C. K. WOODSON

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Title: Two Women, 1862; a Poem

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Release date: January 23, 2017 [eBook #54017]

Most recently updated: October 23, 2024

Language: English

Other information and formats:
www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/54017

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK TWO
WOMEN, 1862; A POEM ***

TWO WOMEN.

TWO WOMEN:

1862.

A POEM.

BY

CONSTANCE FENIMORE WOOLSON.

(REPRINTED FROM APPLETONS' JOURNAL.)

NEW YORK:
D. APPLETON AND COMPANY,
549 AND 551 BROADWAY.
1877.

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1877.

TWO WOMEN.

1862.

ONE.

THROUGH miles of green cornfields that lusty
And strong face the sun and rejoice
In his heat, where the brown bees go dusty
With pollen from flowers of their choice,
'Mong myriads down by the river
Who offer their honey, the train
Flies south with a whirl and a shiver,
Flies south through the lowlands that quiver
With ripening grain—

Fair wheat, like a lady for fancies,
Who bends to the breeze, while the corn
Held stiff all his stubborn green lances
The moment his curled leaf was born;
And grapes, where the vineyards are sweeping
The shores of the river whose tide—
Slow moving, brown tide—holds the keeping
Of War and of Peace that lie sleeping,
Couched lions, each side.

Hair curlless, and hid, and smooth-banded,
Blue innocent maidenly eyes,
That gaze at the lawless rough-handed
Young soldiers with grieving surprise
At oaths on their lips, the deriding
And jestings that load every breath,
While on with dread swiftness are gliding
Their moments, and o'er them is bidding
The shadow of death!

Face clear-cut and pearly, a slender
Small maiden with calm, home-bred air;
No deep-tinted hues you might lend her
Could touch the faint gold of her hair,
The blue of her eyes, or the neatness
Of quaint little gown smoothly spun

Of quaint lace gown, shoddy span
From threads of soft gray, whose completeness
Doth fit her withdrawn gentle sweetness—
A lily turned nun.

Ohio shines on to her border,
Ohio all golden with grain;
The river comes up at her order,
And curves toward the incoming train;
“The river! The river! O borrow
A speed that is swifter— Afar
Kentucky! Haste, haste, thou To-morrow!”
Poor lads, dreaming not of the sorrow,
The anguish of war.

T H E O T H E R .

WEST from the Capital's crowded throng
The fiery engine rushed along,
Over the road where danger lay
On each bridge and curve of the midnight way,
Shooting across the rivers' laps,
Up the mountains, into the gaps,
Through West Virginia like the wind,
Fire and sword coming on behind,
Whistling defiance that echoed back
To mountain guerrillas burning the track,
"Do the worst, ye rebels, that ye can do
To the train that follows, but *I* go through!"

A motley crowd—the city thief;
The man of God; the polished chief
Of a band of gamblers; the traitor spy;
The correspondent with quick, sharp eye;
The speculator who boldly made
His fifty per cent. in a driving trade
At the edge of the war; the clean lank clerk
Sent West for sanitary work;
The bounty-jumper; the lordling born
Viewing the country with wondering scorn—
A strange assemblage filled the car
That dared the midnight border-band,
Where life and death went hand-in-hand
Those strange and breathless days of war.

The conductor's lantern moves along,
Slowly lighting the motley throng
Face by face; what sudden gleam
Flashes back in the lantern's beam
Through shadows down at the rearward door?
The conductor pauses; all eyes explore
The darkened corner: a woman's face
Thrown back asleep—the shimmer of lace

THROWN BACK asleep—the shimmer of lace,
The sheen of silk, the yellow of gold,
The flash of jewels, the careless fold
Of an India shawl that half concealed
The curves superb which the light revealed;
A sweep of shoulder, a rounded arm,
A perfect hand that lay soft and warm
On the dingy seat; all the outlines rare
Of a Milo Venus slumbered there
'Neath the costly silk whose heaviest fold
Subordinate seemed—unnoticed mould
For the form beneath.

The sumptuous grace

Of the careless pose, the sleeping face,
Transfixed all eyes, and together drew
One and all for a nearer view:
The lank clerk hasted, the gambler trod
On the heels of the gazing man of God;
The correspondent took out his book,
Sharpened his pencil with eager look;
The soldiers fought as to who should pass
The first; the lord peered through his glass,
But no sooner saw the sleeping face
Than he too hasted and left his place
To join the crowd.

Then, ere any spoke,

But all eager gazed, the lady woke.

Dark-brown, sleepy, velvet eyes,
Lifted up in soft surprise,
A wealth of hair of auburn red,
Falling in braids from the regal head
Whose little hat with waving plume
Lay on the floor—while a faint perfume,
The roses, crushed in sleep, betrayed,
Tangled within the loosened braid;

Bold features, Nubian lips, a skin
Creamy pallid, the red within
Mixed with brown where the shadow lies
Dark beneath the lustrous eyes.
She smiles; all hearts are at her feet.
She turns; each hastens to his seat.
The car is changed to a sacred place
Lighted by one fair woman's face;
In sudden silence on they ride,
The lord and the gambler, side by side,
The traitor spy, the priest as well,
Bound for the time by a common spell,
And each might be in thought and mien
A loyal knight escorting his queen,
So instant and so measureless
Is the power of a perfect loveliness.

THE MEETING.

THE Western city with the Roman name,
The vine-decked river winding round the hills,
Are left behind; the pearly maid who came
Down from the northern lake whose cool breath fills
The whole horizon, like the green, salt sea,
Is riding southward on the cautious train,
That feels its way along, and nervously
Hurries around the curve and o'er the bridge,
Fearing a rebel ball from every ridge—
The wild adventurous cavalry campaign
That Morgan and his men, bold riders all,
Kept up in fair Kentucky all those years,
So hot with daring deeds, with glowing tears,
That even Peace doth sometime seem a pall,
When men in city offices feel yet
The old wild thrill of "Boots and saddles all!"
The dashing raid they cannot quite forget
Despite the hasty graves that silent lie
Along its route; at home the women sigh,
Gazing across the still untrodden ways,
Across the fields, across the lonely moor,
"O for the breathless ardor of those days
When we were all so happy, though so poor!"

The maiden sits alone;

The raw recruits are scattered through the car,
Talking of all the splendors of the war,
With faces grimed and roistering braggart tone.
In the gray dawning, sweet and fair to view,
Like opening wood-flower pearled with morning dew,
She shines among them in her radiance pure,
Notes all their lawless roughness, sadly sure
They're very wicked—hoping that the day
Of long-drawn hours may safely wear away,
And bring her, ere the summer sunset dies,

~~~~~

To the far farm-house where her lover lies,  
Wounded—alone.

The rattling speed turns slow,

Slow, slower all the rusty car-wheels go,  
The axles groan, the brakes grind harshly down;  
The young conductor comes—(there was a face  
He noted in the night)—“Madam, your place  
Will soon be noisy, for at yonder town  
We take on other soldiers. If you change  
Your seat and join that little lady, then  
It will not seem so lonely or so strange  
For you, as here among so many men.”  
Lifting her fair face from the battered seat,  
Where she had slumbered like a weary child,  
The lady, with obedience full sweet  
To his young manhood’s eager craving, smiled  
And rose. Happy, the flushed youth led the way;  
She followed in her lovely disarray.  
The clinging silk disclosed the archèd foot,  
Hidden within the dainty satin boot,  
Dead-black against the dead-white even hue  
Of silken stocking, gleaming into view  
One moment; then the lady sleepily  
Adjusted with a touch her drapery,  
And tried to loop in place a falling braid,  
And smooth the rippling waves the night had made;  
While the first sunbeams flashing through the pane  
Set her bright gems to flashing back again;  
And all men’s eyes in that Kentucky car  
Grew on her face, as all men’s eyes had done  
On the night-train that brought her from afar,  
Over the mountains west from Washington.

THE LADY (*thinking*).

Haply met,  
This country maiden, sweet as mignonette,  
No doubt the pride of some small Western town:—  
Pity, that she should wear that hopeless gown,  
So prim—so dull—a fashion five years old!

THE MAIDEN (*thinking*).

How odd, how bold,  
That silken robe—those waves of costly lace,  
That falling hair, the shadows 'neath the eyes,  
Surely those diamonds are out of place—  
Strange, that a lady should in such a guise  
Be here alone!

THE LADY.

Allow me, mademoiselle,  
Our good conductor thinks it would be well  
That we should keep together, since the car  
Will soon be overcrowded, and we are  
The only women.—May I have a seat  
In this safe little corner by your side?  
Thanks; it is fortunate, indeed, to meet  
So sweet a friend to share the long day's ride!—  
That is, if yours be long?

THE MAIDEN.

To Benton's Mill.

THE LADY.

I go beyond, not far—I think we pass  
Your station just before Waunona Hill;  
But both are in the heart of the Blue Grass.  
Do you not love that land?

THE MAIDEN.

Aught of it.

I do not know

THE LADY.

Yes; but surely you have heard  
Of the fair plains where the sweet grasses grow,  
Just grass, naught else; and where the noble herd  
Of blooded cattle graze, and horses bred  
For victory—the rare Kentucky speed  
That wins the races?

THE MAIDEN.

Yes; I've heard it said  
They were good worthy horses.—But indeed  
I know not much of horses.

THE LADY.

Then the land—  
The lovely, rolling land of the Blue Grass,  
The wild free park spread out by Nature's hand  
That scarce an English dukedom may surpass  
In velvet beauty—while its royal sweep  
Over the country miles and miles away,  
Dwarfs man-made parks to toys; the great trees keep  
Their distance from each other, proud array  
Of single elms that stand apart to show  
How gracefully their swaying branches grow,  
While little swells of turf roll up and fall  
Like waves of summer sea, and over all  
You catch, when the straight shafts of sunset pass  
Over the lea, the glint of the Blue Grass.—  
But you will see it.

THE MAIDEN.

No; I cannot stay  
But a few hours—at most, a single day.

THE LADY (*unheeding*).

I think I like the best,  
Of all dumb things, a horse of Blue-Grass breed,  
The Arab courser of our own new West,  
The splendid creature, whose free-hearted speed  
Outstrips e'en time itself. Oh! when he wins  
The race, how, pulsed with pride, I wave my hand  
In triumph, ere the thundering shout begins,  
And those slow, cautious judges on the stand,  
Have counted seconds! Is it not a thrill  
That stirs the blood, yet holds the quick breath still?

THE MAIDEN.

I ne'er have seen race-horses, or a race.

THE LADY.

I crave your pardon; in your gentle face  
I read reproof.

THE MAIDEN.

I judge not any man.

THE LADY.

Nor woman?

THE MAIDEN.

If you force reply, I can  
Speak but the truth. The cruel, panting race,  
For gamblers' prizes, seems not worthy place  
For women—nor for men, indeed, if they  
Were purer grown. Of kindred ill the play,  
The dinner loud with wine, the midnight dance,  
The deadly poison of all games of chance—  
All these are sinful.

THE LADY.

Ah! poor sins, how stern  
The judge! I knew ye not for sins—I learn  
For the first time that ye are evil. Go,  
Avaunt ye! So my races are a woe—  
Alas! And David Garrick!—Where’s the harm  
In David?

THE MAIDEN.

I know not the gentleman.

THE LADY.

Nay, he’s a play; a comedy so warm,  
So pitiful, that, let those laugh who can,  
*I* weep. And must I yield my crystal glass,  
Dewy with ice, and fragrant with rare wine,  
That makes a dreary dinner-party pass  
In rosy light, where after-fancies shine—  
Things that one might have said?—And then the dance,  
The *valse à deux temps*, if your partner chance  
To be a lover—

THE MAIDEN.

Madam, pray excuse  
My seeming rudeness; but I must refuse  
To dwell on themes like these.

THE LADY.

Did I begin  
The themes, or you?

THE MAIDEN.

But *I* dwelt on the sin,  
And you—

THE LADY.

Upon the good. Did I not well?  
I gave you good for evil, mademoiselle.

THE MAIDEN.

Forgive me, lady, but I cannot jest,  
I bear too anxious heart within my breast;  
One dear to me lies wounded, and I go  
To find him, help him home with tender care—  
To home and health, God willing.

THE LADY.

Is it so?  
Strange—but ah! no. The wounded are not rare,  
Nor yet the grief, in this heart-rending war.—  
But he will yet recover; I feel sure  
That one beloved by heart so good, so pure  
As yours, will not be taken. Sweet, your star  
Is fortunate.

THE MAIDEN.

Not in the stars, I trust.  
We are but wretched creatures of the dust,  
Sinful, and desperately wicked; still,  
It is in mercy our Creator's will  
To hear our prayers.

THE LADY.

And do you then believe  
He grants all heart-felt prayers? One might conceive  
A case: Suppose a loving mother prays  
For her son's life; he, worn with life's hard ways,  
Entreats his God for death with equal power  
And fervor.

THE MAIDEN.

It is wrong to pray for death.

THE LADY.

I grant it not. But, say in self-same hour  
A farmer prays for rain; with 'bated breath  
A mother, hastening to a dying child,  
Prays for fair weather?—But you do not deign  
To listen. Ah! I saw you when you smiled  
That little, silver smile! I might explain  
My meaning further; but why should I shake  
Your happy faith?

THE MAIDEN.

You could not.

THE LADY.

Nay, that's true;  
You are the kind that walks up to the stake  
Unflinching and unquestioning. I sue  
For pardon, and I pray you tell me all  
This tale of yours. When did your lover fall—  
What battle-field?

THE MAIDEN.

Not any well-known name;  
It was not Heaven's pleasure that the fame  
Of well-known battle should be his. A band  
Of wild guerrillas raiding through the land,  
Shot him, and left him bleeding by the way.

THE LADY.

Guerrillas?

THE MAIDEN.

Yes; John Morgan's.

THE LADY.

Maybe so,  
And maybe not; they bear a seven-leagued name  
That many hide beneath; each shot, each blow,  
Is trumpeted as theirs, and all the blame  
Falls on their shoulders, be it what it may—  
Now truth, and now but falsehood. Morgan's men  
Are bold Kentucky riders; every glen  
Knows their fleet midnight gallop; every map  
Kept by our soldiers here is scored with marks  
Where they have been; now near, now miles away,  
From river lowland to the mountain-gap,  
Swift as the rushing wind. No watch-dog barks  
When *they* ride by, no well-versed tongues betray  
Their resting-place; Kentucky knows her own,  
Gives silent, helpful welcome when they pass  
Across her borders north from Tennessee,  
Heading their horses for the far Blue Grass,  
The land of home, the land they long to see,  
The lovely rolling land. We might have known  
That come they would!

THE MAIDEN.

You are Kentucky-bred?

THE LADY.

I come from Washington. Nay—but I read  
The doubt you try to hide. Be frank—confess—  
I am that mythical adventuress  
That thrives in Washington these troublous days—  
The country correspondent's tale?

THE MAIDEN.

And—something in your air—

THE LADY.

For rare sincerity. Go on.

THE MAIDEN.

Your tone,  
 Your words, seem strange.—But then, I've never known  
 A woman like you.

THE LADY (*aside*).

Yet we are not few,  
Thank Heaven, for the world's sake! It would starve  
If gray was all its color, and the dew  
Its only nectar. With a pulsing haste  
It seeks the royal purples, and draws down  
The luscious bunches to its thirsty taste,  
And feels its blood hot-thrilled, a regal crown  
Upon its brow; and then, its hands do carve  
The vine-leaves into marble.

But the hue  
Of thoughts like these she knows not—and in vain  
To tell her. Yet, sweet snow-drop, I would fain  
Hear her small story.  
(*Speaks.*) Did he fall alone,  
Your gallant soldier-boy? And how to you  
Came the sad news?

#### THE MAIDEN.

A farmer heard him moan  
While passing—bore him to the camp, and there  
A captain from our lake-shore wrote me word  
Ere the brigade moved on; which, when I heard,  
I left my mother, ill, for in despair  
He cried, they wrote, for me. He could not know  
That they had written, for hot fever drove  
His thoughts with whips of flame.—O cruel woe,—O my poor love—  
My Willie!

#### THE LADY.

Do not grieve, fair child. This day  
Will see you by his side—nay, if you will,  
Then lay your head here—weep your grief away.  
Tears are a luxury—yes, take your fill;  
For stranger as I am, my heart is warm  
To woman's sorrow, and this woman's arm  
That holds you is a loyal one and kind.  
(*Thinking.*) O gentle maiden-mind,  
How lovely art thou—like the limpid brook  
In whose small depths my child-eyes loved to look  
In the spring days! Thy little simple fears  
Are wept away. Ah! could *I* call the tears  
At will to soothe the parched heat of my heart!  
—O beautiful lost Faith,  
I knew you once—but now, like shadowy wraith,  
You meet me in this little maiden's eyes,  
And gaze from out their blue in sad surprise  
At the great gulf between us. Far apart,  
In truth, we've drifted—drifted. Gentle ghost  
Of past outgrown, thy land the hazy coast  
Of dreamless ignorance; I must put out  
My eyes to live with you again. The doubt,  
The honest, earnest doubt, is upward growth  
Of the strong mind—the struggle of the seed  
Up to the broad, free air. Contented sloth  
Of the blind clods around it sees no need  
For change—nay, deems, indeed, all change a crime;  
“All things remain as in our fathers' time—  
What gain ye then by growing?”  
“Air—free air!  
E'en though I die of hunger and despair,  
I go,” the mind replies.

THE MAIDEN (*thinking*).

How kind, how warm  
Her sympathy! I could no more resist  
Her questions, than the large clasp of her arm  
That drew me down. How tenderly she kissed  
My forehead! strange that so much good should dwell  
With so much ill. This shining, costly dress,  
A garb that shows a sinful worldliness,  
Troubles my heart.

Ah, I remember well  
How hard I worked after that letter came  
Telling of Willie—and my sisters all,  
How swift we sewed! For I had suffered shame  
At traveling in house-garb.

—I feel a call  
To bring this wanderer back into the fold,  
This poor lost sinner straying in the cold  
Outside the church's pale. Should I not try  
To show her all the sad deficiency,  
The desperate poverty of life like hers,  
The utter falseness of its every breath,  
The pity that within my bosom stirs  
For thinking of the horrors after death  
Awaiting her?

THE LADY.

Quite calm, again? That's well.

Wilt taste a peach? My basket holds a store  
Of luscious peaches. Ah! she weaves a spell,  
This lovely sorceress of fruit; what more  
Can man ask from the earth? There is no cost  
Too great for peaches. I have felt surprise  
Through all my life that fair Eve should have lost  
That mythic Asian land of Paradise  
For a poor plebeian apple! Now a peach,  
Pulpy, pink-veined, hanging within her reach,  
Might well have tempted her.

Oh, these long hours!—

Whence comes this faint perfume of hot-house flowers—  
Tea-roses?

THE MAIDEN.

Tangled in your loosened hair  
Are roses.

THE LADY (*thinking*).

Nita must have twined them there—  
The opera—I know now; I have sped  
So swift across the country, my poor head  
Is turned.—The opera? Yes; then—O heart,  
How hast thou bled! [*Dashes away tears.*]  
(*Speaks.*) Sweet child, I pray you tell  
Again your budding romance, all the part  
Where he first spoke. You'd known him long and well,  
Your Willie?

THE MAIDEN.

Yes; in childhood we had been  
Two little lovers o'er the alphabet;  
Then one day—I had grown to just sixteen—  
Down in the apple-orchard—there—we met,  
By chance—and—

THE LADY (*thinking*).

Blush, thou fine-grained little cheek,  
It comforts me to see that e'en thy meek  
Child-beauty knows enough of love to blush.  
(*Speaks.*) Nay, you flush  
So prettily! Well, must *I* tell the rest?  
You knew, then, all at once, you loved him best,  
This gallant Willie?

THE MAIDEN (*thinking*).

What has come to me  
That I do answer, from reserve so free,  
This stranger's questions? Yet may it not chance  
My confidence shall win hers in return?  
I must press on, nor give one backward glance—  
Must follow up my gain by words that burn  
With charity and Christian zeal.  
(*Speaks.*) Yes; then  
We were betrothed. I wore his mother's ring,—  
And Willie joined the church; before all men  
He made the promises and vows which bring  
A blessing down from God. Dear lady, strength  
From Heaven came to us. Could I endure  
This absence, silence, all the weary length  
Of hours and days and months, were I not sure  
That God was with my Willie? If on you  
Sorrow has fallen, lady (and those tears  
Showed me its presence), seek the good, the true,  
In this sad life; a prayer can calm all fears;  
Yield all your troubles to your God's control,  
And He will bless you. Ah! where should *I* be  
Did I not know that in my Willie's soul  
Came first the love of God, then love for me?

THE LADY.

His love for you comes *second*?

THE MAIDEN.

Would you have  
A mortal love come first?

THE LADY.

Sweet heart, I crave  
Your pardon. For your gentle Christian zeal  
I thank you. Wear this gem—'twill make me feel  
That I am something to you when we part.  
But what the “silence?”

THE MAIDEN.

Ten months (they seem years!)  
Since Willie joined the army; and my heart  
Bore it until his letters ceased; then tears  
Would come—would come!

THE LADY.

Why should the letters cease?

THE MAIDEN.

I know not; I could only pray for peace,  
And his return. No doubt he could not write,  
Perplexed with many duties; his the care  
Of a thronged camp, where, ever in his sight,  
The new recruits are drilled.

THE LADY (*thinking*).

Oh, faith most rare! (*Speaks.*) Had you no doubts?

THE MAIDEN.

Why should I doubt? We are  
Betrothed—the same forever, near or far!  
—He knew my trust  
Was boundless as his own.

THE LADY.

But still you must  
In reason have known something—must have heard  
Or else imagined—

THE MAIDEN.

For three months no word  
Until this letter; from its page I learned  
That my poor Willie had but just returned  
To the brigade, when struck down unaware.  
It seems he had been three months absent.

THE LADY.

—Where?

THE MAIDEN.

They did not say. I hope to bear him home  
To-morrow; for in truth I scarce could come,  
So ill my mother, and so full my hands  
Of household cares; but, Willie understands.

THE LADY (*thinking*).

*Ciel!* faith like this is senseless—or sublime!  
Which is it?  
(*Speaks*). But three months—so long a time—

THE MAIDEN.

Were it three years, 'twould be the same. The troth  
We plighted, freely, lovingly, from both  
Our true hearts came.

THE LADY (*thinking*).

And may as freely go—  
Such things have happened! But I will not show  
One glimpse of doubt to mar the simple trust  
She cherishes; as soon my hand could thrust  
A knife in the dove's breast.  
(*Speaks.*) You'll find him, dear;  
All will go well; take courage. Not severe  
His wound?

THE MAIDEN.

Not unto death; but fever bound  
His senses. When the troops moved on, they found  
A kindly woman near by Benton's Mill;  
And there he lies, poor Willie, up above  
In her small loft, calling, in tones that thrill:  
"Oh, come to me, my love, my love, my love!"—  
Here is his picture.

THE LADY.

What! 'tis Meredith!  
The girl is mad!—Give it me forthwith!  
How came you by it?

THE MAIDEN.

Madam, you will break  
The chain. I beg—

THE LADY.

Here is some strange mistake.  
This picture shows me Meredith Reid.

THE MAIDEN.

Yes, Reid  
Is Willie's name; and Meredith, indeed,  
Is his name also—Meredith Wilmer. I  
Like not long names, so gave him, lovingly,  
The pet name Willie.

THE LADY.

O ye Powers above!  
The “pet name Willie!” Would you try to chain  
Phœbus Apollo with your baby-love  
And baby-titles? Scarce can I refrain  
My hands from crushing you!—

You are that girl,  
Then, the boy’s fancy. Yes, I heard the tale  
He tried to tell me; but it was so old,  
So very old! I stopped him with a curl  
Laid playfully across his lips. “Nay, hold!  
Enough, enough,” I said; “of what avail  
The rest? I know it all; ’tis e’er the same  
Old story of the country lad’s first flame  
That burns the stubble out. Now by this spell  
Forget it all.” He did; and it was well  
He did.

#### THE MAIDEN.

Never! oh, never! Though you prove  
The whole as clear as light, I’d ne’er receive  
One word. As in my life, so I believe  
In Willie!

#### THE LADY.

Fool and blind! your God above  
Knows that I lie not when I say that he  
You dwarf with your weak names is mine, mine, mine!  
He worships me—dost hear? He worships *me*,  
Me only! What art thou, a feeble child,  
That *thou* shouldst speak of loving? Haste, aside,  
Lest we should drown you in the torrent wild  
Of our strong meeting loves, that may not bide  
Nor know your dying, even; feeble weed  
Tossed on the shore—[*The maiden faints.*  
Why could I not divine  
The truth at first? [*Fans her.*  
Fierce love, why shouldst thou kill  
This little one? The child hath done no ill,  
Poor wounded, broken blossom. I should pour  
My gentlest pity—

THE MAIDEN (*recovering*).

Madam, thanks; no more  
Do I require your aid.

THE LADY (*aside*).

How calm she seems,  
How cold her far-off eyes! Poor little heart.  
The pity of it! all its happy dreams,  
With a whole life's idolatry to part  
In one short moment.

(*Speaks.*) Child, let us be friends;  
Not ours the fault, it is the work of Fate.  
And now, before your hapless journey ends,  
Say, in sweet charity, you do not hate  
Me for my love. Trust me, I'll tend him well;  
As mine own heart's blood, will I care for him  
Till strong again. Then shall he come and tell  
The whole to you—the cup from dregs to brim—

How, with undoubting faith  
In the young fancy that he thought was love  
For you, he came a-down the glittering path  
Of Washington society; above  
The throng I saw his noble Saxon head,  
Sunny with curls, towering among the rest  
In calm security—scorn that is bred  
Of virtue, and that largeness which your West  
With its wide sweep of fields gives to her sons—  
A certain careless largeness in the look,  
As though a thousand prairie-miles it took  
Within its easy range.

Ah! blindly runs  
Our fate. We met, we two so far apart  
In every thought, in life, in soul, in heart—  
Our very beings clashed. He, fair, severe;  
I, dark and free; his days a routine clear,  
Lighted by conscience; I, in waking dream  
Of colors, music, warmth, the scents of flowers,  
The sweep of velvet, and the diamond's gleam,  
A cloud of romance heavy on the air,  
The boudoir curtained from the light of day,

Where all the highest came to call me fair,  
And whispered vows I laughed in scorn away.  
Was it my fault that Nature chose to give  
The splendid beauty of this hair, these eyes,  
This creamy skin? And if the golden prize  
Of fortune came to me, should I not live  
In the rich luxury my being craved?  
I give my word, I no more thought of time—  
Whether 'twas squandered, trifled with, or saved,  
Than the red rose in all her damask prime.  
Each day I filled with joys full to the brim—  
The rarest fruits and wines, the costliest lace,  
The ecstasy of music, every whim  
For some new folly gratified, the grace  
Of statues idealized in niches, touch  
Of softest fabrics. Ah! the world holds much  
For those who love her; and I never heard  
In all my happy glowing life one word  
Against her, till—he came!

We met, we loved,

Like flash of lightning from a cloudless sky,  
So sudden, strange, the white intensity—  
Intensity resistless! Swift there moved  
Within his heart a force unknown before,  
That swept his being from that early faith  
Across a sea, and cast it on the shore  
Prone at my feet.

He minded not if death  
Came, so he could but gaze upon my face.

—But, bending where he lay (the youthful grace  
Of his strong manhood, in humility  
Prone, by love's lightnings), so I bended me  
Down to his lips, and gave him—all!

Sweet girl,

Forgive me for the guiltless robbery,

Forgive him, swept by fateful Destiny!  
He spoke of one, the child-love of his youth;  
I told of my child-marriage. But, in truth,  
No barrier, had it been a thousand-fold  
Stronger than boyish promise, e'er could hold  
Natures like ours!

                    You see it, do you not?  
You understand it all.

                                            —I had forgot,  
But this the half-way town; the train runs slow,  
No better place than this. But, ere you go,  
Give me one silent hand-clasp, little pearl.  
I ask you not to speak, for words would seem  
Too hard, too hard. Yet, some time, when the dream  
Of girlhood has dissolved before the heat  
Of real love, you will forgive me, sweet.

THE MAIDEN.

I fail to comprehend you. Go? Go where?

THE LADY.

Back to your home; here waits the north-bound train;  
'Twill bear you safely. To go on were pain  
Most needless—cruel.

THE MAIDEN.

I am not aware  
That I have said aught of returning. Vain  
Your false and evil story. I have heard  
Of such as you; but never, on my word  
As lady and as Christian, did I think  
To find myself thus side by side with one  
Who flaunts her ignominy on the brink  
Of dark perdition!

Ah! my Willie won  
The strong heart's victory when he turned away  
From your devices, as I *know* he turned.  
Although you follow him in this array  
Of sin, I *know* your evil smiles he spurned  
With virtuous contempt—the son of prayers,  
The young knight of the church! My bosom shares  
His scorn; take back your ring, false woman. Go!  
Move from my side.

THE LADY.

Dear Heaven, now I know  
How pitiless these Christians!

Unfledged girl,  
Your little, narrow, pharisaic pride  
Deserves no pity; jealousy's wild whirl  
Excuse might be, since that is born of love;  
But *this* is scorn, and, by the God above,  
I'll set you in your place!

Do *you* decide  
The right and wrong for this broad world of ours,  
Poor little country-child, whose feeble eyes  
Veiled o'er with prejudice are yet so wise  
That they must judge the earth, and call it good  
Or evil as it follows their small rules,  
The petty, narrow dogmas of the schools  
That hang on Calvin!

Doubtless prairie-flowers  
Esteem the hot-house roses evil all;  
But yet I think not that the roses should  
Go into mourning therefor!

Oh, the small,  
Most small foundation for a vast conceit!  
Is it a merit that you never learned  
But one side of this life? Because you dwelt  
Down in a dell, there were no uplands sweet,  
No breezy mountain-tops? *You* never yearned  
For freedom, born a slave! You never felt  
The thrill of rapture, the wild ecstasy  
Of mere existence that strong natures know,  
The deep and long-drawn breaths, the burning glow  
Of blood that sunward leaps; but, in your dell,  
You said: "This is the world. If all, like me,  
Walked on this one straight line, all would go well!"

O fool! O blind!  
O little ant toiling along the ground!

You cannot see the eagle on the wind  
Soaring aloft; and so you go your round  
And measure out the earth with your small line,  
An inch for all infinity! "Thus mine  
Doth make the measure; thus it is."

Proud girl!

You call me evil. There is not a curl  
In all this loosened hair which is not free  
From sin as your smooth locks. Turn; look at me!  
I flout you with my beauty! From my youth  
Beside my mother's chair, by God's own truth,  
I've led a life as sinless as your own.  
Your innocence is ignorance; but I  
Have seen the Tempter on his shining throne,  
And said him nay. You craven weaklings die  
From fear of dangers I have faced! I hold  
Those lives far nobler that contend and win  
The close, hard fight with beautiful, fierce Sin,  
Than those that go untempted to their graves,  
Deeming the ignorance that haply saves  
Their souls, some splendid wisdom of their own!

You fold

Yourself in scornful silence? I could smile,  
O childish heart, so free from worldly guile,  
Were I not angered by your littleness.

You judge my dress

The garb of sin? Listen. I sat and heard  
The opera; by chance there fell a word  
Behind me from a group of men who fill  
Night after night my box. My heart stood still.  
I asked—they told the name. "Wounded," they said,  
"A letter in the journal here." I read,  
Faced them with level eyes; they did not know,  
But wondered, caught the truth, to see me go  
Straight to my carriage. "Drive! The midnight train."  
We reached it, breathless.

Had I worn fair white,  
A ballroom-robe, I'd do the same to gain  
One moment more of time.

THE MAIDEN.

And by what right—  
Are you his wife?

THE LADY.

I am not; but to-night  
I shall be, if I live. Your scorn, poor child,  
Is thrown away. Bound by his soldier's oath,  
I would not keep him. No Omphale I,  
Though he be Hercules. We plighted troth,  
And then, when called, he went from me—to die  
If need be. I remember that I smiled  
When they marched by!

Love for my country burns  
Within my heart; but this was love for him.  
I could not brook him, one who backward turns  
For loving wife; his passion must not dim  
The soldier's courage stern. Then I had wealth,  
The golden wealth left me by that old man  
Who called me wife for four short months; by stealth  
He won me, but a child; the quiet plan  
Was deftly laid. I do not blame him now.  
My mother dead—one kind thought was to save  
My budding youth from harm. The thoughtless vow  
I made was soon dissevered by the grave,  
And I was left alone. Since then I've breathed  
All pleasures as the flowers breathe in the sun,  
At heart as innocent as they; red-wreathed  
My careless life with roses, till the one  
Came! Then the red turned purple deep, the hope  
Found itself love; the rose was heliotrope.

There needed much  
To do with lawyers' pens ere I could give  
My hand again; so that dear, longed-for touch  
Was set by me for the full-blooming day  
When Peace shall drive the demon War away  
Forever. I was wrong. Oh, let him live,  
Kind God! Love shall be wronged no more—no more.  
All my own heart's life will I gladly pour  
For one small hour of his.—Wait—wait—I fly

To thee, my love, on swiftest wings! Thy cry  
The depths of grief too hot for tears doth move:  
“Oh, come to me, my love, my love, my love!”

THE MAIDEN.

It was not you he called!

THE LADY.

Ah! yes.

THE MAIDEN.

He is  
*Not* false; I'll ne'er believe it, woman.

THE LADY.

His  
The falseness of the pine-tree, felled, upturned  
By the great flood, and onward madly borne  
With the wild, foaming torrent miles away.—  
No doubt he loved the violet that grew  
In the still woods ere the floods came; he knew  
Not then of roses!

THE MAIDEN.

Cruel eyes, I say  
But this to all your flashings—you have lied  
To me in all!

THE LADY.

Look, then, here at my side  
His letters—read them. Did he love me? Read!  
Aha! you flush, you tremble, there's no need  
To show you more; the strong words blanch your cheek.  
See, here his picture; could I make it speak,  
How it would kill you! Yes, I wear it there  
Close to my heart. Know you this golden hair  
That lies beside it?

THE MAIDEN.

Should he now confess  
The whole—yes, tell me all your tale was true,  
I would not leave him to you, sorceress!  
I'd snatch him from the burning—I would sue  
His pardon down from heaven. I shall win  
Him yet, false woman, and his grievous sin  
Shall be forgiven.  
(*Bows her head upon her hands.*) O God let him die  
Rather than live for one who doth belie  
All I have learned of Thee!

*Train stops suddenly.—Enter* CONDUCTOR.

CONDUCTOR.

The bridge is down,  
The train can go no farther. Morgan's band  
Were here last night! There is a little town  
Off on the right, and there, I understand,  
You ladies can find horses. Benton's Mill  
Is but a short drive from Waunona Hill.—  
Can I assist you?

THE MAIDEN.

Thanks; I must not wait. [*Exit.*]

THE LADY.

Yes; that my basket—that my shawl. O Fate!  
How burdened are we women! Sir, you are  
Most kind; and may I trouble you thus far?  
Find me the fleetest horses; I must reach  
Waunona Hill this night. I do beseech  
All haste; a thousand dollars will I give  
For this one ride. [*Exeunt.*]

A SOLDIER.

Say, boys, I'd like to live  
Where I could see that woman! I could fight  
A regiment of rebels in her sight—  
Couldn't you?

THE OTHERS.

Yes—yes! [*Exeunt omnes.*]

# ***THE DRIVE.***

THE LADY (*thinking*).

O fair Kentucky! border-land of war,  
Thou rovest like a gypsy at thy will  
Between the angry South and stubborn North.  
Across thy boundaries many times from far  
Sweep Morgan's men, the troopers bold who fill  
Ohio with alarm; then, marching forth  
In well-drilled ranks with flag, and fife, and drum,  
From camp and town the steady blue-coats come,  
March east, march west, march north, march south, and find  
No enemy except the lawless wind.  
No sooner gone—Lo! presto through the glen  
Is heard the midnight ride of Morgan's men:  
They ford the rivers by the light of stars,  
The ringing hoofs sound through the mountain-pass;  
They draw not rein until their glad huzzas  
Are echoing through the land of the Blue Grass.

—O lovely land,

O swell of grassy billows far and near,  
O wild, free elms, whose swaying arms expand  
As if to clasp me, hold my love as dear  
As thine own son! I hasten to his side—  
Ye roads, lie smooth; ye streams, make safe the ford;  
O chivalrous Kentucky, help the bride  
Though thou hast wounded with thy rebel sword  
The foeman bridegroom!

.....

.... Can it be that girl  
Who rides in front? I thought her left behind  
In that small town. *Ciel!* would I could hurl  
The slim thing down this bank! Would I could bind  
Those prim, long-fingered, proper hands of hers  
Behind her drooping, narrow-shouldered back,  
And send her home! A heart like that transfers  
Its measured, pale affections readily,  
If the small rules it calleth piety

Step in between them. Otherwise, the crack  
Of doom would not avail to break the cord  
Which is not love so much as given word  
And fealty, that conscientiousness  
Which weigheth all things be they more or less,  
From fold of ribbon to a marriage-vow,  
With self-same scales of duty. Shall I now  
Ride on and pass her—for her horse will fail  
Before the hour is out? Of what avail  
Her journey?  
(*Speaks.*) Driver, press forward.—Nay, stop—  
(*Aside.*) O what a child am I to waver thus!  
I know not how to be ungenerous,  
Though I may try—God knows I truly tried.  
What's this upon my hand? Did a tear drop?  
(*Speaks.*) By your side  
Behold me, maiden; will you ride with me?  
My horses fleet and strong.

THE MAIDEN.

I thank you—no.

THE LADY (*aside*).

She said me nay; then why am I not free  
To leave her here, and let my swift steeds go  
On like the wind?  
(*Speaks.*) Ho! driver—  
(*Aside.*) But, alas!  
I cannot.  
(*Speaks.*) Child, my horses soon will pass  
In spite of me; they are so fleet they need  
The curb to check them in their flying speed.  
Ours the same journey: why should we not ride  
Together?

THE MAIDEN.

Never!

THE LADY.

Then I must abide  
By your decision.—Driver, pass.  
(*Thinking.*) I take  
Her at her word. In truth, for her own sake  
'Twere charity to leave her, hasten on,  
Find my own love, and with him swift be gone  
Ere she can reach him; for his ardor strong  
(Curbed, loyal heart, so long!),  
Heightened by fever, will o'ersweep all bounds,  
And fall around me in a fiery shower  
Of passion's words.— And yet—this inner power—  
This strange, unloving justice that surrounds  
My careless conscience, *will* not let me go!  
(*Speaks.*) Ho!  
Driver, turn back.

—Maiden, I ask again—  
I cannot take advantage. Come with me;  
That horse will fail you soon—ask; both these men  
Will tell you so.—Come, child—we will agree  
The ride shall count as naught; nay, when we reach  
The farm-house, all shall be as though no speech  
Had ever passed between us—we will meet  
Beside his couch as strangers.  
(*Speaks.*) There's defeat  
For thee, O whispering tempter!

THE MAIDEN (*to the men*).

Is it true?

Will the horse fail?

ONE OF THE MEN.

Yes.

THE MAIDEN.

Madam, then with you  
I needs must ride.—I pray you take my share  
Of payment; it were more than I could bear  
To be indebted to you.

THE LADY.

Nay—the sum  
Was but a trifle.  
(*Aside.*) Now forgive me, truth.  
But was it not a trifle to such wealth—  
Such wealth as mine?  
(*Speaks.*) Heard you that distant drum  
Borne on the wind a moment? Ah! our youth  
Is thrilled with the great pulses of this war.  
How fast we live—how full each crowded hour  
Of hot excitements! Naught is done by stealth,  
The little secrecies of other days  
Thrown to the winds; the clang and charge afar  
On the red battle-field, the news that sways  
Now to, now fro, 'twixt victory and defeat;  
The distant cry of “Extra!” down the street  
In the gray dawns, and our breathless haste  
To read the tidings—all this mighty power  
Hath burned in flame the day of little things,  
Curled like a scroll—and now we face the kings,  
The terrible, the glorious gods of war.  
—The maid forgets her shyness; wherefore waste  
One moment when the next may call him forth  
Ne’er to return to her? The dear old North  
May take her lover—but he shall not go  
With lips unkissed to meet his Southern foe;  
Her last embrace will cheer him on his round  
Now back, now forth, over the frozen ground  
Through the long night.

—And when the hasty word  
“Only one day; be ready, love,” is heard,  
The soft consent is instant, and there swells  
Amid the cannonade faint wedding-bells  
From distant village; then, as swift away  
The soldier bridegroom rides—he may not stay.  
And she?—She would not keep him, though the tears

Blind her sweet eyes that follow him, and fears  
Crowd her faint heart and take away her breath,  
As on her white robe falls the shade of Death  
That waits for him at Shiloh!

O these days!

When we have all gone back to peaceful ways,  
Shall we not find sweet Peace a little dull?  
—You do not speak.

THE MAIDEN.

Madam, my heart is full

Of other thoughts.

THE LADY.

Of love?—Pray—what is love?  
How should a woman love?—Although we hate  
Each other well, we need not try to prove  
Our hate by silence—for there is a fate  
Against it in us women; speak we must,  
And ever shall until we're turned to dust,  
Nay—I'm not sure but even then we talk  
From grave to grave under the churchyard-walk—  
Whose bones last longest—whose the finest shroud—  
And—is there not a most unseemly crowd  
In pauper's corner yonder?

—You are shocked?

You do not see, then, that I only mocked  
At my own fears—as those poor French lads sang  
Their gayest songs at the red barricade,  
Clear on the air their boyish voices rang  
In chorus, even while the bayonet made  
An end of them.—He may be suffering now—  
He may be calling—

There! I've made a vow

To keep on talking. So, then—tell me, pray,  
How should a woman love?

THE MAIDEN.

I can but say

How I do love.

THE LADY.

And how?

THE MAIDEN.

With faith and prayer.

THE LADY.

I, too; my faith is absolute. We share  
That good in common. I believe his love  
Is great as mine, and mine—oh, could I prove  
My love by dying for him, far too small  
The test; I'd give my love, my soul, my all,  
In life, in death, in immortality,  
Content in hell itself (if there be hells—  
Which much I doubt)—content, so I could be  
With him!

THE MAIDEN.

Is it a woman's tongue that tells  
This blasphemy? When I said faith, I meant  
A faith in God.

THE LADY.

And God is love! He sent  
This love that fills my heart. Oh, most divine—  
Oh, nearest to him of all earthly things,  
A love that passeth self—a love like mine  
That passeth understanding. The bird sings  
Because it is the only way he knows  
To praise his Maker; and a love that flows  
Like mine is worship, too—a hymn that rolls  
Up to the God of Love, who gave us souls  
To love with. Then the hidden sacrifice;  
It formed a part of worship once, and I  
Do hold it now the part that deepest lies  
In woman's love, the dim sanctuary  
Behind the veil, holy of holies, kept  
E'en from the one she loves: all told, except  
This mystic feeling which she may not know  
How to express in words—the martyr's glow  
Idealized—the wish to give him joy  
Through her own suffering, and so destroy  
All part that self might play—to offer pure  
Her love to her heart's idol. Strange, obscure,  
Sacred, but mighty, is this longing; I  
Can feel though not define it. I would die  
To make him happy!

THE MAIDEN.

As his happiness  
Depends on me, then can you do no less  
Than yield him to me—if you love him thus.

THE LADY (*thinking*).

“As,” said she? Heart, but this is fabulous,  
This calm security of hers!  
(*Speaks.*) Why, child,  
Hast never heard of passion, and its wild,  
Impetuous, unreasoning assault  
On souls that know not their own depths? The fault  
Not his: he was but young, he did not know  
Himself. Might he not love me even though  
Thou wert the best? Have pity! I appeal  
To all the woman in thee. Dost thou feel  
That one touch of his hand would call the blood  
Out from thy heart in an o’erwhelming flood  
To meet it?

THE MAIDEN.

Nay, I know not what you speak.

THE LADY.

Thou dost not, that I see. Thy pearly cheek  
Keeps its fair white.

Sweet child, he’s that and more  
To me. Ah, let me kneel; thus I implore  
That thou wouldst yield him to me—all the right  
His boyhood promise gave thee.

THE MAIDEN.

In the sight  
Of Heaven we are betrothed; I cannot break  
My word.

THE LADY.

Oh, not for mine, but for *his* sake!  
He loves me!

THE MAIDEN.

Only madness, that will burn  
And die to ashes; but, the fever past,  
The old, pure love will steadfastly return  
And take its rightful place.

THE LADY.

But should it last,  
This fever-madness? should he ask your grace,  
And say he loved me best?

THE MAIDEN.

Then, to his face  
I'd answer, Never! What! leave him to sin?

THE LADY.

And what the sin?

THE MAIDEN.

You! you! You have no faith,  
No creed, that I can learn. The Bible saith  
All such are evil.

THE LADY (*aside*).

Why did I begin  
Such hopeless contest?  
(*Speaks.*) Child, if he should lie  
Before us now, and one said he must die  
Or love me, wouldst thou yield?

THE MAIDEN.

Never; as dead  
He would be in God's hands; living—

THE LADY.

In mine.

THE MAIDEN.

That is, in atheism.

THE LADY.

Have I said  
Aught atheistical? Because my faith  
Is broader than its own, this conscience saith  
I am an atheist! Ah, child, is thine  
A better faith? Yet, be it what it may,  
Should he now lie before us here, and say  
He loved thee best, I'd yield him though my heart  
Should stop—though I should die. Yea, for his sake,  
To make him happy, I would even take  
Annihilation!—let the vital spark  
Called soul be turned to nothing.

THE MAIDEN.

Far apart  
Our motives; mine is clear with duty—

THE LADY.

Dark  
And heavy mine with love.

THE MAIDEN.

You talk of death  
With frequent phrase, as though a little thing,  
A matter merely of the will and breath,  
It were to face the judgment, and the King  
Who has not summoned you. Your flippant tongue  
Rolls out its offers as a song is sung,  
And, both mean nothing; for the chance to die  
For one we love, that glorious gift, comes now  
But rarely in this life that you and I  
Must bear our part in. Thus, no empty vow  
Do *I* repeat; and yet, I surely know,  
At duty's call right calmly could I go  
Up the red scaffold's stairs.

THE LADY.

I well believe  
Thee, steadfast maiden-voice. Nay, I conceive  
*My* love, *thy* duty, are alike—the same  
Self-sacrifice under a various name  
According to our natures. I would yield,  
And thou refuse to yield, from the same love;  
I'd have him happy here, and thou—above.  
For thus we look at life.

The book is sealed  
That holds our fate—we may not look within;  
But this I know, that, be it deadly sin  
Or highest good, he loves me!

THE MAIDEN.

There are loves—  
And loves!

THE LADY.

So be it. All this word-work proves  
Nothing. Then let it end. Though there's a charm  
In speech—but you are tired. 'Twill be no harm  
To rest you on my shoulder, though its creed  
(Poor shoulder!) is not orthodox.

THE MAIDEN.

Indeed,  
I need not rest.

THE LADY.

Well, then, I'm half asleep  
Myself, and you the silent watch may keep.—  
(*Thinking.*) I've whiled the time away; but, thou dear God,  
Who made me, how with bleeding feet have trod  
The toiling moments through my heart! I pray  
(For I believe that prayer may aid the soul,  
Though not the body nor the fixed control  
Of Nature) that his love may hold its sway  
E'en as I saw him last, when, at my feet,  
He lavished his young heart in burning tide  
Of loving words. Oh, not for mine own joy,  
But his, I pray this prayer; do thou destroy  
All my own part in it.—Ah, love, full sweet  
Shall be our meeting. Lo! the longed-for bride  
Comes—of her own accord. There is no bliss,  
Even in heaven, greater than the kiss  
That I do keep for thee!

THE MAIDEN (*thinking*).

O God, thy will  
Be done—yes, first of all, be done! (Bide still,  
Thou wicked, rebel heart!) Yet, O Lord, grant  
This grace to me, a lowly suppliant.  
My mind is vexèd, evil thoughts do rage  
Within my soul; O Merciful, assuage  
The suffering I endure!—If it is true  
My poor boy loves this woman—and what is  
Is ever for the best—create anew  
Her soul that it may surely leaven his  
With holiness. Oh, stretch Thy mighty arm  
And win her to Thy fold, that she may be  
A godly woman, graced with piety,  
Turned from the error of her ways, the harm  
Of all her worldliness, the sinful charm  
Of her fair face (if it be fair, though I  
Think her too brown) changed by humility  
To decorous sweetness.—

Lord, look in my heart;  
I may not know myself; search every part,  
And give me grace to say that I will yield  
My love to hers if Thy will stands revealed  
In his swift preference.

Yet, in pity, hear—  
Change her, Lord—make her good! [*Weeps.*]

THE LADY (*thinking*).

Is that a tear  
On her soft cheek? She has her little griefs,  
Then, as the children have; their small beliefs  
Are sometimes brought to naught—no fairies live,  
And dolls are sawdust!—

Love, I do forgive  
Your boyish fancy, for she's lily fair;  
But no more could content you now than dew  
Could hope to fill Niagara with its rare,  
Fine drops that string the grass-blade's shining hue,  
Upon the brink.—Dearest, I call! Oh, see  
How all my being rushes toward thee! Wait,  
E'en though before thine eyes bright heaven's gate  
Let out its light: angels might envy thee  
Such love as I shall give thee—wait! oh, wait!

# ***T H E   F A R M - H O U S E .***

THE LADY.

THE sun is setting, we have passed the mill  
Some time; the house is near Waunona Hill,  
But the road smooth this way—which doth account  
For the discrepancy of names. The gleam  
Of the low sun shines out beneath that mass  
Of purple thunder-cloud; when we surmount  
This little swell of land, its slanting beam  
Will light up all the lances of the grass,  
The steely hue, the blue of the Blue Grass.

.....

That is the house off on the right; I know  
By intuition.

THE MAIDEN.

It may hold—the worst!

THE LADY.

Art faint?

THE MAIDEN.

'Twill pass. Lady, I enter first—  
First and alone!

THE LADY.

Child, if I thought his heart  
Longed for the sight of you, I'd let you go;  
Nay, I would make you! As it is—  
But no,  
It cannot be.

THE MAIDEN (*clasping her hands*).

Lord, give me strength! I yield;  
Go you the first. Ah! [*Sobs*.

THE LADY.

Yours the nobler part;  
I cannot yield. (And yet it is for him  
I hold this “cannot” firm.) What might you wield  
With that unflinching conscience-power! See, dim  
Mine eyes—

There; we will go together—thus!  
God help us both! [*They enter the house*.

Yes, we have come, we two,  
His nearest, dearest. Is it perilous,  
The fever? Where—above? That stair? We go—  
Come, child—come, child.

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

Dear ladies, you should know  
Before—

THE LADY.

Come!

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

He—

THE LADY.

Child, must I wait for you  
Here at his door!

THE MAIDEN.

I come; but something cold  
Has touched my heart.

THE LADY.

Then stay, coward!

THE MAIDEN.

Nay, hold;  
I come. [*They mount the stairs together.*  
(*Crying out above.*) But he is dead—my Willie!

THE LADY (*above*).

Fate,  
You've gained the day at last! Yes, he is dead!

# ***BY THE DEAD.***

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

He died last night at three—quite easily.

THE LADY.

Alone?

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

A surgeon from the camp was here.

THE LADY.

Where is the man?

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

Gone back.

THE LADY.

Send for him.

See,

Here is a trifle; though it cannot clear  
Our debt to you, yet take it.

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

Too much.

But you give

THE LADY.

Keep it.

THE MAIDEN (*kneeling by the bedside*).

O Willie! can I live  
Without you? Love, my love, why are you dead  
And I alive? O noble, golden head,  
Whose every curl I know, how still you lie  
On this poor pillow, and how dreamlessly  
You sleep! But waken now; look on me, dear;  
Open those close-shut eyes, for I am here—  
Yes, here all this long way from home. Oh, speak—  
Speak to me, Willie.—Ah, how cold his cheek—  
How icy cold! O God! he's dead, he's dead!

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

Yes, he is dead, dead as King David. Truth  
He was right handsome for a Yankee youth—  
Rode his horse well.

THE LADY (*aside*).

I love you, Meredith.

THE MAIDEN.

What's this upon the table near his hand? [*Opens the package.*  
My picture—yes, my letters—all! Herewith  
I know—I know he loved me!

THE LADY (*thinking*).

Cover worn,  
Creased in its folds, unopened, and forlorn—  
Yes, I remember it. I would not look  
Within;—unopened since that day.  
He took  
The poor thing forth with dying loyalty  
To send to her.

THE MAIDEN.

O Lord, I understand  
Thy purpose; 'twas to try my faith. I kneel  
To thank thee that mercy doth reveal  
The whole to my poor heart. He loved me—me,  
Me only!

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE.

Would you like to see the wound  
Here in his arm?—Why, if she hasn't swooned!

THE LADY.

Take her below, and care for her, poor child!

*[Exit woman, carrying the maiden in her arms.]*

Brain, art thou wild,  
Distraught, that thou canst all things calmly hear  
And answer, when my pulses reel, my heart  
Stands still, and cold through every vital part  
Death breathes his icy breath?

Oh, my own love!  
I clasp thee in my arms, come back to me!  
O ice-cold lips I kiss, ye are as dear  
As ever! Come! Thy idol waits for thee,  
Waits—weeps.

Dost thou not hear me there above  
Where thou hast gone? Come back and take the bride  
Who nestles weeping, longing, at the side  
Of thy deserted body. Oh! most fair  
Thy earthly tenement, the golden hair  
Curls as when my poor fingers twined it last,  
Thy head upon my breast. O brownèd cheek!  
Can I not warm thee with mine own? Oh, speak—  
Speak to me, Meredith!

Poor wounded arm,  
Dear blood; here will I hold thee close and warm  
Upon my heart. Dost thou not feel me now?  
And now? And now? Do I not hold thee fast?  
Hast thou not longed for me?

I gave my vow  
To be thine own. See! I am come. My hand  
I lay in thine. Oh, speak to me! Command  
My every breath; full humbly I obey,  
The true wife longs to feel a master's sway,  
Longs to do homage, so her idol prove  
Ruler—nay, despot of her willing love.  
Didst thou not hear me whisper while she spoke

Durst thou not hear me whisper while she spake.

“I love thee—oh, I love thee, Meredith?”

I would not that her childish grief should break

Thy peace up in thy heaven; even there

Thou longest for my love, and near the stair

Where souls come up from earth thou’rt standing now

Watching for me. O darling, from thy brow

I catch the radiance!

She is not thine,

Thou art not hers. The boyish pledge wherewith

She strives to hold thee was the radiancy

Of early dawn, which now the mighty sun

Hath swept away in fervent heat; nor thee

Nor her it binds. Her pretty youth will run

Its swift course to some other love; Fate

Ne’er lets such sweet maids pine, though they may try;

A few months lent to tearful constancy,

The next to chastened sorrow, slow decline

To resignation; then, the well-masked bait

Of making some one happy, though at cost

Of sweet self-sacrifice, which soon is lost

In that content which, if not real love,

Looks strangely like it! But why should I prove

What thou dost know already, freed from time

And finite bonds, my darling?

Love sublime,

Art thou not God? Then let him down to me

For one short moment. See! in agony

I cling to the cold body; let him touch

Me once with this dear hand; it is not much

I ask—one clasp, one word.

What! nothing? Then

I call down vengeance on this God of men

Who makes us at his will, and gives us hearts

Only to rend them in a hundred parts,

And see them quiver—bleed! I, creature, dare

To call aloud for justice; my despair

to call aloud for justice, my despair  
Our great far-off Creator doth arraign  
Before the bar to answer for the pain  
I suffer now. It is too much—too much!  
O woe! woe! woe! the human soul can such  
Intensity of sorrow not withstand,  
But, lifting up on high its fettered hand,  
Can only cry aloud in agony,  
And blindly, wildly curse its God and die!

How dare you take,  
You Death, my love away from me? The old,  
The weak, the loveless, the forlorn, were there  
In crowds, and none to miss them. But your cold  
And heartless eye did mark that he was fair,  
And that I loved him? From your dreadful hold  
I snatch my darling, and he yet shall wake  
From out your sleep by my caresses. See,  
See how I love him! Ah, shall I not win  
His life back with my lips, that lovingly  
Do cling to his? And, though you do begin  
Your icy work, these arms shall keep him warm—  
Nay, more: my loving verily disarm  
E'en you, O King of Terrors! You shall turn  
And give him back to me; a heart shall burn  
Under your ribs at last from very sight  
Of my fierce, tearless grief.

—O sorry plight  
Of my poor darling in this barren room,  
Where only his gold curls do light the gloom!  
But we will change all that. This evening, dear,  
Shall be our bridal: wilt thou take me, here,  
And thus?—in this array—this falling hair—  
Crushed robes? And yet, believe me, I am fair  
As ever.

Love, love, love! oh, speak to me!  
I will not listen in my misery  
If thy heart beat

if my heart beat—

God! it is cold!

*[Falls to the floor.]*

*Enter the SURGEON.*

SURGEON.

Art ill,

Madam?—

THE LADY (*rising*).

Thanks, sir. But sorrow cannot kill.  
Would that it could! Nay, I sit by his side—  
Thus. Now tell all—all—all.

SURGEON.

You cannot hide  
The deadly faintness that has paled your cheek;  
Let me get—

THE LADY.

Nothing. Nothing can avail,  
Good sir; my very heart's blood has turned pale.  
Struck by God's lightning, do you talk to me  
Of faintness? Only tell your tale—speak, speak;  
You saw him die?

SURGEON.

I did; right tranquilly  
He passed away this morning, with your name  
Upon his lips—for you are Helena?

THE LADY.

I am.

SURGEON.

I saw your picture.  
(*Aside.*) Yes, the same.  
Hair, eyes. What Titian tints!  
(*Speaks.*) He made me lay  
Your letters and your picture on his heart  
Before he died; he would not from them part  
For e'en one moment.

THE LADY.

Lift them not, they're mine;  
My hand alone must touch the holy shrine  
Of love and death where the poor relics lie—  
Darling (*bends, and kisses the letters*), because you loved them!  
Let them die,  
Go to the grave with him, there on his breast,  
Where I would gladly die too—be at rest  
Forever.—And he spake of me?

SURGEON.

He said  
That you would come, for he had sent you word.

THE LADY.

I ne'er received it; 'twas by chance I heard,  
A passing chance.

SURGEON.

The lines were down—

THE LADY.

And may  
They never rise again that failed that day,  
And left him dying here! Go on; he said—

SURGEON.

That you would come, and grieved that o'er his head  
The turf might close ere you could reach his side  
And give him one last kiss.

And then—he died.

THE LADY.

No more?

SURGEON.

The owner.—Then

He said—

SURGEON.

To give it you, for you would know  
Its history, and where it swift should go;  
The name was writ within.

THE LADY (*aside*).

Yes, love; amen!

Be it according to thy wish.

*(Speaks.)* Pray take

This fee, good sir. I would that for his sake—

Your kindness to him—I could send your name

Ringling through all the West in silver fame.—

At dawn, you said, the burial? Then leave

Me here alone with him. I well believe

You'll show me further kindness. Speak no word

Beyond your doctor's art to that poor child

Who weeps below. I would not that she heard

Aught more of grief.

*[Exit SURGEON.]*

Ah! all my passion wild

Has gone; now come the softening woman tears.—

Forgive me, great Creator, that I spake

In my sharp agony. O do thou take

The bitterness from out my soul; I know

Naught, but thou knowest all! Then let my woe,

The poor blind woe we short-lived mortals bear,

Be my sad plea.—

I knew, through my despair,

You loved me to the last. Death had no fears

For you, my love; you met him with my name,

As talisman of the undying flame

That leaps o'er the black chasm of the grave

And mounts to heaven. But I will not rave,

When you died softly.

Ah! you love me there

As well as here. God never made me fair

For nothing; now, I know the gift he gave

That I might take my place with you at last,

Equal in loveliness, though years had passed

Since you first breathed the air above the skies,

The beauty-giving air of paradise.  
Fair are you now, my love, but not like me:  
Mine is the goddess-bloom, the rarity  
Of perfect loveliness; yours, the bright charm  
Of strong young manhood, whose encircling arm  
Could bend me like a reed. Oh, for one clasp  
Of that strong arm!—

Hist! was not that the hasp  
Of the old door below? She comes; I hear  
Her light step on the stair.

Darling, no fear  
Need trouble you upon your couch; to me  
A sacred trust this gentle girl shall be  
Through life. Did you not love her once?

THE MAIDEN (*entering*).

I pray  
Forgiveness thus to leave you here so long;  
I did not mean it, but I swooned away  
Before I knew it.

THE LADY.

Thanks. There was no wrong;  
I liked the vigil.

THE MAIDEN (*going to the bedside*).

Sweet those eyes—the brow  
How calm! I would not bring life to him now  
E'en if I could; gone to his God—at rest  
From all earth's toil.

Dear love, upon thy breast  
I lay my hand; I yield thee back to Him  
Who gave thee to me; and, if thou hast wrought  
Wrong to our troth in deed, or word, or thought,  
I now forgive thee. Sleep in peace; the dim,  
Dark grave has its awaking.

As the hart  
Longed for the water-brooks, so have I yearned  
For token, Willie, that thy love returned  
To me at last. Lo! now I can depart  
In peace.—My picture, letters! Thou wast true,  
Wast true to me, thank God!—  
(*Turning.*) Madam, to you  
I owe apology.

THE LADY.

Never! But throw  
Your gentle arms around me—thus. And so  
Give me a blessing.

THE MAIDEN.

But I've robbed you—you  
Who loved him also; though to me was due  
This love of his; at least—

THE LADY.

Sweet doubter, yes;  
I grant thee all. But, as I kneel, O bless  
This heart that bows before thee; all its sin—  
If it be sin—forgive; and take, within  
Thy pure love, me, thy sister, who must live  
Long years—long years! O child, who dost forgive  
More than thou knowest, lay thy sister-hand  
In blessing!

THE MAIDEN.

Though I do not understand,  
Yet will I thus content thee: Now the Lord  
Bless thee, and keep thee by his holy word;  
Be gracious to thee, that thy faith increase;  
Lift up his countenance, and give thee peace,  
Now and forever!

THE LADY.

Amen. May it prove—  
This peace—what thou dost think it.

THE MAIDEN.

I must go;  
The horses wait for me. Now that I know  
He's safe with God, the living claim my care.—  
My mother—ah, full selfish was the love  
That made me leave her so; I could despair  
Of mine own self, if God were not so good,  
Long-suffering, and kind.

O could I stay!  
But I must reach the train at break of day.  
I take my letters and the picture.—Should  
Your duties call you not so soon, oh wait,  
See his dear head laid low by careful hand,  
And say a prayer above the grave.

THE LADY (*aside*).

O Fate,  
How doth she innocently torture—rack  
My soul with hard realities! I stand  
And hear her talk of graves!—O God, the black,  
Damp earth over my darling!

THE MAIDEN (*turning to the bedside*).

Love, farewell!  
I kiss thee once.—Lady, you do not mind?  
It was but once. I would not seem unkind;  
I would not wound you needlessly.

THE LADY (*aside*).

O swell,  
Proud heart, to bursting, but gainsay her not!

THE MAIDEN.

I know full well that yours the harder lot,  
Dear lady; but, forgive me, he was mine  
Long, long before. It were too much to ask  
That I should not be glad his heart returned  
To me, his bride betrothed—to know he yearned  
For me before he died. I cannot mask  
My joy because you loved him too.

THE LADY.

Nay, thine  
All joy that thou canst take; I would not rob  
Thee of one little hair's-breadth.

THE MAIDEN (*laying her head on the pillow*).

Oh, farewell,  
My love! my love! my love! [*Weeps*].

THE LADY.

Child, do not sob.  
Come to me—let me hold you; who can tell,  
Perhaps he hears you, though so still. We'll stand  
Together by his side—thus, hand-in-hand—  
And gaze on his calm face.

WOMAN OF THE HOUSE (*below*).

The wagon's here.

THE MAIDEN.

Alas! and I must hasten. Kiss me, dear;  
Indeed, I love you now.

THE LADY.

And I have tried  
To make you. [*They embrace.*—*Exit* MAIDEN.

THE LADY (*throwing herself down beside the body*).

Meredith, art satisfied?

***EARTH TO EARTH.***

WRAPPED in his cloak, they bore him forth at dawn,  
The soldier dead, dead in his gallant strength,  
Young manhood's prime. The heavy fold withdrawn  
Showed his calm face; while all his rigid length  
Lay stiff beneath the covering, the feet  
Turned up to heaven like marble. Breezes played  
Soft in his curling hair, the fragrance sweet  
Of the wild-brier roses incense made,  
And one bird sang a chant.

Yet recks it not,  
This quiet body going to its grave,  
Feet foremost, folded hands, if the storm rave  
Or the sun shine. Henceforth nor part nor lot  
Hath it with men—the tale is told, all's o'er;  
Its place shall know its step, its voice, no more;  
Its memory shall pass away; its name,  
For all its evil or for all its worth,  
Whether bedecked with reverence or blame,  
Shall soon be clean forgotten.—

Earth to earth!

The lady walked alone. Her glorious hair  
Still held its roses crushed; the chill despair  
That numbed her being could not dim the light  
Of all her flashing jewels, nor the bright  
Sheen of her draperies.

The summer sun  
Rose in the east and showed the open grave  
Close at her feet; but, ere the work begun—  
Lowering the clay (O proud humanity!  
Is this thy end?)—she gentle signal gave  
To lay the body down, and, by its side  
Kneeling, kissed brow and lips, fondly as bride  
Might kiss; and, as she clung there, secretly  
A shining ring left on the cold dead hand,

And covered it from view; then slowly rose  
And gave them place.

But ere the tightening rope  
Had done its duty, o'er the eastern slope  
Rode horsemen, and the little group of those  
Who gazed, drew back, and eyed askance the band.  
They turned, they drew their reins—a sight to see  
Indeed, this lady clad so royally,  
Alone, beside a grave.

She raised her eyes,  
And the bold leader bared his lofty head  
Before her to his saddle-bow; the guise  
Of bold, rough-riding trooper could not hide  
The gallant grace that thus its homage paid  
To so much beauty. At his signal mute,  
The little band, Kentucky's secret pride,  
His daring followers in many a raid  
And many a hair-breadth 'scape, made swift salute,  
And, all dismounting, honor to the dead  
Paid silently, not knowing 'twas their own  
Bullet by night that laid him there:—so strange  
The riddle of men's life, its little range  
Thick with crossed fates, though each one stands alone  
To mortal eyes.

The rope slackened, the clay  
Had reached its final resting-place. Then she  
Who loved him best, in all her rich array  
Stepped forth, and, kneeling, with her own hands cast  
The first clod on his heart. "I yield to thee,  
Nature, my only love. Oh, hold him fast

As sacred trust!  
'Earth to earth, ashes to ashes, dust to dust!' "  
Then, rising, with her lovely face upturned  
To the clear sky, where the first sunbeams burned,  
"I know that my Redeemer lives," she said;  
"He that believes on him, though he were dead,  
... ..

Yet shall he live!”

And so passed from their sight.

The troopers ride away,  
On to the south; the men who fill the grave  
With hurried shovelfuls in whispers say,  
“That’s part of Morgan’s band.” And one, a slave,  
Looks down the road, and mutters: “That was him—  
Young Cap’en Morgan’s self! These eyes is dim,  
But they knows Morgan! Morgan!—what! why, bless  
Your hearts, *I* know him, and I know Black Bess—  
'Twas Bess he rode.”

And now the work is done;  
On from their northern raid the troopers pass  
Fleet to the south; the grave is filled, and gone  
Even the slave.

Forever still, alone,  
Her letters and bright picture on his breast,  
Her sparkling spousal-ring on his dead hand,  
The golden-haired young soldier lies at rest  
Where o’er his head the steely shadows pass,  
Far in the fair Kentucky border-land,  
The lovely, rolling land of the Blue Grass.

**1 8 6 4 .**

**W A S H I N G T O N .**

THE LADY (*with an open letter*).



MARRIED! Nay, now the little vexing fear  
That troubled the calm hollow of my grief  
With its small aching is withdrawn, and clear  
The certainty—she never loved him. Brief  
Her forgetting—brief!—But I will not chide;  
All happiness go with thee, gentle bride,  
And of my gold a sister's share!

To wed  
Another, and once his! O golden head  
Under the grass, how jealous is my heart  
Of thy remembrance! Yet I should be glad  
She loved thee not, for then no evil part  
I played, e'en though unconsciously.

Oh, mad,  
Mad, mad my love for thee! the same to-day—  
The same, the same. I could not be a wife—  
I could not stop the sun! No love but thee,  
My own, my own! no kiss but thine—no voice  
To call me those sweet names that memory  
Brings back with tears. Ah! had I any choice,  
I still must love thee down beneath the sod  
More than all else—though grandest soul that God  
Had ever made did woo me. Love, my heart  
Is thine, and ever must be thine; thy name  
Is branded there!

Yet must I live my life.

SERVANT (*announcing*).

The Count.

THE LADY.

Another? Ah! poor fools. The game  
Doth while away my time. Yes, I do play  
My part with smiles that are not wholly feigned,  
For life is strong, and I am young.—There reigned  
A queen once, who, though dead, could not lay down  
Her long-used sceptre; with her jeweled crown  
Upon her head, she sat and meted out  
Reward and justice; nor did any doubt  
Her life was gone. Were not her robes the same—  
Her jewels bright? And had she not a name  
Borne wide upon the winds for loveliness?  
She could not stop—she needs must reign—*noblesse  
Oblige!* So I.

But she—married! a wife!  
Who once was his! Oh, horrible! a life  
Of treason to his memory, a long  
Lie! But, ah! no, she never loved him. *I*  
Do hold myself as his, and loyally,  
Royally, keep my vow.

SERVANT.

What shall I say,  
Madam?

THE LADY (*speaks*).

Show in the Count.  
(*Aside.*) Ah! well-a-day!  
One must do something.

THE COUNT (*entering*).

*Madame, je viens—*

***L A K E   E R I E .***

THE MAIDEN (*rising from her knees*).

My marriage-morning! Lord, give me thy grace  
For the new duties of a wedded life.

The letters have I burned;

And now—the picture. Oh, dear boyish face,  
One look—the last! Yet had I been thy wife,  
Willie, I had been true to thee—returned  
All thy affection to the full.

She said

Love was “a sacrifice.” It is; as—thus:  
Get thee behind me, Past! [*Burns the picture.*

—Which one of us

Was truest? But why ask? She wronged the dead  
With many lovers—nay, her very dress  
Showed not one trace of sorrow.

—I confess

I never thought her fair, although the throng  
Do call her so, they tell me.

—Long, how long

I wore the heavy crape that checked my breath,  
And went about as one who sorroweth;  
And I did sorrow! Slow months passed, and I  
Gave every thought to tearful memory;  
My grief grew selfish.

Then—he brought his suit—

My mother wept and prayed. What right had I  
To crush two lives? If by the sacrifice  
I make them happy, is it not large price  
For my poor, broken years? How earnestly  
I strove to do the right!

The patient fruit

Of years of prayer came to my aid, and now  
I stand in bridal white. Lord, hear my vow:  
Oh, may I make him happy! Not a thought  
Of any other love shall mar the troth  
I give for *this* life. Evils, troubles, naught

But death, shall part us. Thus the marriage-oath.  
But after—*then*—O Willie!

THE MOTHER (*entering*).

Art thou dressed?  
That's well, dear one. Never has mother blessed  
A child more dutiful, more good.  
Come, love,  
The bridegroom waits.

THE END.



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## TWO WOMEN:

A POEM.

BY CONSTANCE FENIMORE WOOLSON.

[REPRINTED FROM APPLETONS' JOURNAL.]

*From the Springfield Republican.*

“Miss Constance Fenimore Woolson’s poem, ‘Two Women,’ begun in the January and finished in the February number of APPLETONS’ JOURNAL, is of such remarkable quality as to deserve a wider reading than it is likely to have. To read it in completeness gives one, beyond its faults—which are principally those of imperfect versification and a certain formality of phraseology—a sense of power in character-drawing (coloring enough, too, for that matter), in dramatic situation and in expression of deep emotions,

which is rarely met with. The contrast between the magnificent woman of the world and the Puritan country-girl is done in true masterly way, and that the one should continue faithful to love through her life, though still reigning in social royalty, while the other marries as piously as she mourned, and puts away the dead youth's memory forever—is perfectly true to their natures. To present such marked types in rivalry, and show the self-abnegation in the rich nature and the innocent self-absorption of the narrow nature, was well worth while. The poem would make quite a little book, and better merits such treatment than most verses that receive it.”

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“In the poem ‘Two Women,’ the first half of which appeared in the January number of APPLETONS’ JOURNAL, and the last half of which has just now come to us in the February number of that magazine, there is something, we think, which takes the piece out of the category of ordinary magazine-work, and entitles it to special attention. The poem is long enough, for one thing, to fill a little volume, if it were printed as it is the custom to print books of poetry, and while it is rugged, faulty, and in many respects defective, it is nevertheless strong, dramatic, and full of the flavor of the soil. The two women who gave it its name are types of two well-defined classes of American women, but they are sharply drawn as individuals also, and their characters are presented with a boldness and a degree of distinctness which is possible only at the hands of a writer of very considerable dramatic power.”

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